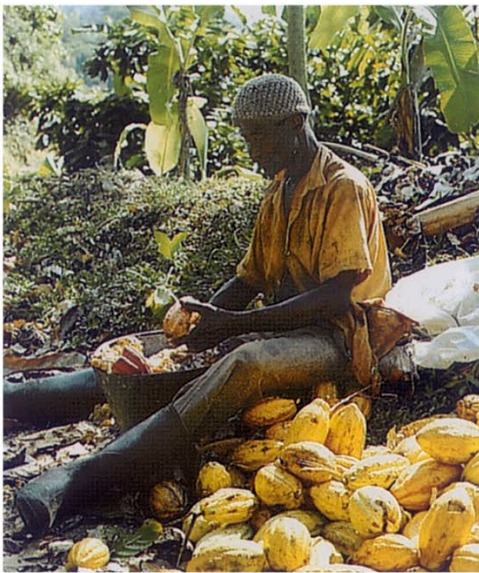


Medicinal Actions & Uses Laxative and astringent, the fruit gently improves bowel regularity without excessively irritating the colon. It forms part of the classic Ayurvedic Triphala formula, used chiefly as a bowel tonic. Like Chinese rhubarb (*Rheum palmatum*, p. 126), chebulic myrobalan may be used as a treatment for diarrhea and dysentery. The fruit's tannins protect the gut wall from irritation and infection, and tend to reduce intestinal secretions. Likewise, the fruit helps to counter acidic indigestion and heartburn. A decoction of chebulic myrobalan may be used as a gargle and mouthwash, as a lotion for sore and inflamed eyes, and as a douche for vaginitis and excessive vaginal discharge. The fruit has been also shown to have liver-protective and antidiabetic properties.

Caution Do not take chebulic myrobalan during pregnancy.

Theobroma cacao (Sterculiaceae) Cacao, Cocoa

Description Evergreen tree growing to 26 ft (8 m). Has pale brown bark, glossy oval leaves, clusters of small yellow flowers, and large, pear-shaped, red-yellow seed pods.



Cacao is cultivated in tropical regions around the world. The seed pulp is the source of cocoa.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Mexico and Central America, cacao is now a major crop throughout the tropics. The seed pods are harvested several times a year and are cut directly from the trunk of the tree (where they grow). One pod contains up to 50 beans, with roughly 900 weighing 2¼ lb (1 kg). According to the World Cocoa Foundation, world production of cacao in 2012 was more than 3.8 million tons.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents The unprocessed seed pulp contains high levels of polyphenols (mostly proanthocyanidins and catechins), xanthines (including caffeine), a fixed oil, and many constituents responsible for chocolate's flavor. Due to fermentation and the processing involved, chocolate has significantly reduced levels of polyphenols. Minute quantities of endorphins (powerful painkillers that occur naturally within the body) are also present in cacao.

History & Folklore The word "chocolate" derives from *chocolatl*, the name given to this tree by the Aztecs. In 1720, Cotton Mather, an American preacher and natural historian, praised cacao, writing that the plant "supplies the Indian with bread, water, wine, vinegar, brandy, milk, oil, honey, sugar, needles, thread, linen, clothes, caps, spoons, besoms, baskets, paper, and nails; timber, coverings for their houses; masts, sails, cordage for their vessels; and medicine for their diseases; and what can be desired more?"

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though cacao is most often used as a food, it also has therapeutic value as a nervous system stimulant. In Central America and the Caribbean, the seeds are taken as a heart and kidney tonic. The plant may be used to treat angina, and as a diuretic. Cacao butter (the fixed oil) makes a good lip salve and is often used as a base for suppositories and pessaries.

Research The potent mix of polyphenols in the unprocessed seed pulp has been the main focus of research into cacao. These have a protective activity on the heart and blood vessels, particularly supporting the capillaries or microcirculation. Cacao consumption is linked with lower blood pressure and cholesterol levels, as well as a reduced risk of coronary heart disease and stroke. It also appears to have an antidiabetic activity, stimulating the pancreas to regulate blood sugar levels more effectively. Other potential uses of cacao that have been investigated include the prevention of tooth decay, as an aid to weight loss, as a cancer-preventative food within the diet, and as a treatment for chronic fatigue.

Thuja occidentalis (Cupressaceae) Arborvitae

Description Evergreen tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has scale-like leaves, male and female flowers, and small, egg-shaped cones.

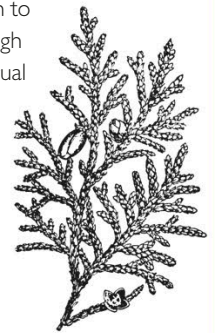
Habitat & Cultivation Native to the northeastern U.S. and also known as white cedar, arborvitae flourishes in wet, marshy ground and along riverbanks. It has become a popular ornamental tree in Europe. The leaves are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Arborvitae contains a volatile oil (up to 60% thujone), coumarins, flavonoids (including procyanidin), tannins, and polysaccharides.

History & Folklore Many Native American peoples prized arbor-vitae as a medicine for fever, headaches, coughs, swollen hands, and rheumatic problems. The herb was burned as a smudge (smoky fire) for its scent and to ward off evil spirits. The 19th-century Eclectic herbalists used arbor-vitae as a remedy for bronchitis, rheumatism, and uterine cancer. Arborvitae has also been used to treat the side-effects of the smallpox vaccination.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Arborvitae has an established antiviral activity. It is most often used to treat warts and polyps, being prescribed both internally and externally for these conditions. It is also used as part of a regime for treating cancer—especially cancer of the uterus. Arborvitae makes an effective expectorant and anti-congestion remedy, and may be used to treat acute bronchitis and other respiratory infections. It induces menstruation and can be taken to bring on delayed periods, though this use is inadvisable if menstrual pain is severe. Arborvitae is diuretic and is used to treat acute cystitis and bed-wetting in children. Extracts of the herb may be painted on painful joints or muscles as a counterirritant, improving local blood supply and easing pain and stiffness.



Arborvitae twig

⚠ Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Do not take arborvitae during pregnancy or while breastfeeding.

Self-help Use Warts, p. 304.

Thymus serpyllum (Lamiaceae) Wild Thyme

Description Tuft-forming evergreen herb growing to a height of 3 in (7 cm). Has square stems, small aromatic oval leaves, and spikes of bright mauve flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, thyme prefers heaths, moorland, and barren places. The herb is collected when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Flowering tops.

Constituents Wild thyme contains a volatile oil (with thymol, carvacrol and linalool), flavonoids, caffeic acid, tannins, and resin. The volatile oil's properties are similar to, but less potent than, those of thyme oil (from *Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143).

History & Folklore The 17th-century herbalist Nicholas Culpeper advised taking wild thyme to treat internal bleeding, coughing, and